

Metonymy

Metonymy (/mɛˈtɒnəmi/)^[1] is a figure of speech in which a thing or concept is referred to by the name of something closely associated with that thing or concept.^[2]

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The Kremlin, pictured, is a common metonymy used to refer to the primary complex of the Government of Russia or the USSR.

Etymology

The words *metonymy* and *metonym* come from the Greek μετωνυμία, *metōnymía*, "a change of name", from μετά, *metá*, "after, beyond", and -ωνυμία, *-ōnymía*, a suffix that names figures of speech, from ὄνυμα, *ónyma* or ὄνομα, *ónoma*, "name".^[3]

Background

Metonymy and related figures of speech are common in everyday speech and writing. Synecdoche and metalepsis are considered specific types of metonymy. Polysemy, multiple meanings of a single word or phrase, sometimes results from relations of metonymy. Both metonymy and metaphor involve the substitution of one term for another.^[4] In metaphor, this substitution is based on some specific analogy between two things, whereas in metonymy the substitution is based on some understood association or contiguity.^{[5][6]}

American literary theorist Kenneth Burke considers metonymy as one of four "master tropes": metaphor, metonymy, synecdoche, and irony. He discusses them in particular ways in his book *A Grammar of Motives*. Whereas Roman Jakobson argued that the fundamental dichotomy in trope was between metaphor and metonymy, Burke claims that the fundamental dichotomy is between irony and synecdoche, which he also describes as the dichotomy between dialectic and representation, or again between reduction and perspective.^[7]